CANNABIS

Also known as weed, marijuana, hash or skunk

KNOW THE RISKS
Cannabis can affect memory, mood, mental health and reaction time. The risks vary with age, how often it is used and the strength of THC.

What is cannabis?

Cannabis comes from the cannabis plant. THC is the main ingredient that causes a high. Cannabis can be smoked, vaped or eaten in food. Stronger forms may cause more intense and unpredictable effects.

How can cannabis affect you?

Short-term: Some people feel relaxed, while others experience panic, anxiety, confusion, poor memory, slower reactions or paranoia.

Dependence and withdrawal: Regular use can lead to dependence. Cutting down or stopping may cause sleep problems, irritability, low mood, restlessness or cravings.

Mental health: Cannabis can trigger severe anxiety, paranoia or psychotic symptoms in some people. Frequent use, especially of high-THC products, is linked to increased risk.

Driving and accidents

Cannabis can affect judgement, attention, balance and reaction time. **Never drive or use machinery while affected.**

WARNING SIGNS NOT TO IGNORE
Severe paranoia, hearing or seeing things others do not, unusual beliefs, major confusion or sudden changes in behaviour may need prompt medical assessment.

THE KEY MESSAGE
Being common does not make cannabis risk-free. Speak early, without judgement.

RECOGNISE THE SIGNS. GET HELP EARLY.

Practical information for individuals, parents and families.

When to seek help

Seek medical advice if someone is severely confused, paranoid, hearing voices or seems detached from reality. **Call 999 if there is immediate danger or risk of harm.**

What you can do

If cannabis is affecting sleep, mood, work or relationships, speak to a GP or drug service. Parents and carers: ask calm questions, listen first and avoid blame or shame.

UK law | England and Wales

Cannabis is a **Class B controlled drug.**

POSSESSION: Up to **5 years in prison**, an unlimited fine, or both.

SELLING OR SUPPLYING: Up to **14 years in prison**, an unlimited fine, or both.

DRUG-DRIVING: A **minimum 1-year driving ban**, up to 6 months in prison, an unlimited fine and a criminal record.

Prison terms are maximum penalties. Police may issue a warning or fixed penalty in some cases. Lawful prescriptions are subject to different rules.

Families, stigma and support

Fear of judgement can stop people seeking help. Mental health problems need care, not blame. A calm conversation or an offer to attend an appointment can help.

Free local support in Rochdale

TURNING POINT / ROAR | Adults: drug and alcohol support
0300 555 0234

EARLY BREAK | Young people and families
0161 723 3880

THE SALIK PROJECT UK | Community education and help finding support
contact@salikprojectuk.org

Seeking help is a sign of strength, not shame.

Sources: NHS medical cannabis guidance; GOV.UK drugs penalties and drug-driving law; THINK! drug driving. Reviewed November 2026.